



Sales on the Apple iTunes store crossed **2 Billion** songs in the second week of February.



SanDisk Sansa Fuze 4 GB



SanDisk Sansa Fuze 8 GB



Apple iPod Nano

shape, but not as long as the iPod Nano. In fact, it resembles a squat looking device from the previous generation called the Nano 3G (the current generation being the Nano 4G). These players have mat rubberised finishes on the rear, while the front is finished with a smooth gloss. Both the front and the rear share common colours and makes the players look plain. The only attractive colour option is the grey that looks really chic, but this colour is available for the 8-GB version only.

Fuze also uses the clickwheel-type design that Apple made famous. However, its clickwheel actually moves as you spin your finger, unlike the iPod that senses finger movements and jogs through the menu system while remaining stationary. The clickwheel on the Fuze is too sensitive in our collective opinion and it takes little for it to skip to the next function.

In fact, navigating to the desired option can be tricky if you do not watch it carefully. A little more pressure will cause it to skip a couple of options and move on ahead. The Fuze is fully loaded with an FM Radio, video capabilities, besides reading e-books and an in-built microphone to record audio. These players come with microSD expansion slots, so the ability to upgrade storage capacity is always present.

Performance

Both the SanDisk Sansa Fuze players are excellent performers. Initially, when we found the Apple players offering somewhat harsh and sibilant highs with the SR 225 headphones, we figured that it was because of their ruthlessly revealing nature. However, the highs are extended

on the Fuze, but not harshly, nor is there any sibilance. Some may like this, some may want that extra bit of treble sparkle, but it's a lot easier on one's ears.

On the iPod Nano, the drum cymbals clinch our suspicion that this PMP has a slightly over emphasised top-end. However, the Nano's mid-range performance with vocals and guitar is impeccable. Fuze can be referred to as a more neutral option over the Nano. Bass reproduction on both these PMPs is similar. The Sony NWZ-E436F was in fact the only player that was not able to drive the Grados well enough. Guitar plucks seemed a little unfocussed and seemed to lack a proper rounded, musical feel to them. Although it gets the sound staging quite well, it loses out on picking up the finer sounds. It did perform well with its bundled earphones, but we didn't find it as good. The major battle here was between Apple and SanDisk. SanDisk wins, although only by a very slight margin. We're pretty surprised to see the sibilance rear its ugly head once too often for the Apple Nano, because this was not the case with the iPod Touch that was part of our reference system.

Guts and Glory: Who won and why

The Best Performer award is a tie and goes to the duo from SanDisk. Both the Fuze 4 GB and its twin the Fuze 8 GB are simply the best all-round performers in this test. They beat the Apple iPod Nano 4G by the slimmest of margins, but as the proverb goes – a miss is as good as a

mile. The Best Value winner in our sub-Rs. 5,000 category is the Creative Zen Stone Plus. At just Rs. 3,499, this player is superb value for money. It offers very good performance and the addition of a tiny screen is a plus for those managing multiple playlists. It's also compact enough to fit almost any pocket inconspicuously. For those of you looking at really good performance, but not necessarily 8 GB of storage space, we suggest the SanDisk Sansa Fuze 4 GB. This player is priced at Rs. 6,890, and frankly offers a load of features for the price. The fact that it jointly won the Best Performance award, too, and offers superlative battery life, is an added bonus.

If you're looking for something without a screen and ultra compact, then our hearty recommendations are with the Apple iPod Shuffle. For such a tiny player, it's got superb sound quality. It is the best sounding PMP in the sub-Rs. 5,000 price bracket and lost out from getting our Best Buy recommendation only because it misses out on certain features. If you want something really cheap that has a large screen, but not necessarily the best screen, Mitashi's MWI-4GA should satisfy. For the record, the Apple iPod Nano 4G has the best quality display from among all the participants (in this test) and is also one of the most attractive looking with several truly lively colour options. The brand value does not come cheap and we figure that for Rs. 9,700, this player is grossly overpriced. ■

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